Meredith

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Book 4: The Vanguard

Chapter 1: The First Drop-Off

Scene 1: The Garage Barracks

The weight of the blankets in the converted garage was a heavy, grounding anchor. David woke to the familiar, rhythmic breathing of the three girls surrounding him. He was pinned securely in the center of the massive, custom-built bed. Meredith's arm was thrown heavily over his chest from the left, acting as a human weighted blanket against his morning spasticity. To his right, Kate was curled on her side, perfectly bracketed by Morgan on the far edge.

It was perfectly safe. It was entirely routine. But David still felt the hollow ache in his chest where Hannah was supposed to be.

He blinked against the early morning light filtering through the blinds, doing the math in his head. *Six hours.* Hannah was still fast asleep in the dark of Pearl Harbor. He let out a low, sustained hum—a sound of quiet longing. Meredith shifted instantly, her eyes cracking open. She didn't ask what was wrong; she just squeezed his shoulder and gave a single, understanding nod. Hannah had promised to call later that afternoon, and the entire family was counting down the hours until they heard from her.

"Alright, troops," Morgan murmured, her voice raspy as she sat up and stretched her arms toward the ceiling. "Up and at 'em. It's syllabus day."

The morning routine commenced with clinical, loving efficiency. Modesty was a concept that simply did not exist within the walls of the garage. It had been burned away by years of necessity. Morgan and Meredith threw back the covers and seamlessly transitioned into caregiving mode, stripping off pajamas and moving directly into the adjoining accessible bathroom. It was a rapid, practiced blur of warm water, soap, and mechanical transfers.

"Careful with the shit hose, Mer," Morgan deadpanned, holding up a fresh towel as Meredith expertly flushed Kate's MACE system. "You know she's got a big day of functioning as a respectable adult today."

Kate, sitting securely in her shower chair, let out a sudden, breathy series of silent giggles, her shoulders shaking at the toilet humor. David caught her eye and offered a double-blink of amusement. But beneath Kate's laughter, David could see the subtle, lingering shadow that hadn't been there a year ago. It was only recently that the protective fog around Kate's literal processing had begun to lift. She was just starting to piece together the terrifying reality that Connor's "safe ride home" hadn't just been a reckless accident—it had been a trap. She was finally understanding what he would have done to her if the Holt sedan hadn't wrapped around that utility pole.

Meredith caught the shift in Kate's eyes too. She didn't offer empty pity. She just kissed the top of Kate's wet, chestnut-red hair and efficiently attached the fresh urinary bag. "You look beautiful today, Kate. Doctor's appointment at ten to check the hardware, and then we're going to watch movies. You and David are eighteen. You call the shots today."

Morgan leaned over the double vanity, pulling her heavy hair up into a massive, utilitarian claw clip. She paused, catching her reflection in the harsh bathroom light. A distinct, half-inch band of natural sun-kissed ash was creeping in at her scalp, stark against the dark brunette dye she'd meticulously maintained for the last year.

She tilted her head, inspecting the roots, and then looked at Meredith's reflection right beside her. Meredith's natural waist-length ash hair was exactly the same shade as Morgan's roots.

"I think I'm done with the dye," Morgan announced suddenly, letting the heavy brunette mass fall back down her back.

Meredith paused, holding a clean shirt for David. "You're ditching the brunette? Why?"

A slow, wicked grin spread across Morgan's face, her "Fire" protocol already calculating the possibilities. "Because if we go back to being completely identical, we can play Twin Magic again. Think about the tactical advantage. Someone gives Kate a hard time, you step in and quietly warn them off. They walk away, turn a corner, and boom—I'm standing right there, looking exactly like you, ready to ruin their day. It'll make us look like we can teleport."

David let out a sharp, amused huff from his wheelchair, his lips twitching into a smile at the sheer chaos Morgan was planning to inflict on the world.

"It's going to take a lot of chemical stripper to get that dark box dye out," Meredith noted pragmatically.

"I know. I'll call Tracy," Morgan said, pulling a ribbed tank top over her head. "I'll make an appointment to ask about color removal for this afternoon, right after we get her hardware checked."

Scene 2: The Commute

The drive from the quiet perimeter of Delaney Street to the concrete sprawl of downtown Norfolk took about thirty minutes. David watched the city wake up through the passenger window of the modified family van, the heavy, resistive-touch OmniTalk 3000 already clamped securely to his manual wheelchair's frame. He felt a tightening in his chest—a spike of sensory anticipation. Today was his very first day of college at the Community College of Hampton Roads. There were no high school IEP meetings here, no familiar aides, just thousands of strangers and his freshman SDV 100 orientation class.

"We've got some extra time," his dad said, navigating the morning traffic with practiced ease since his own office was located right in the heart of downtown Norfolk. "Let's hit the Rocket Burger drive-thru. Get you some real food before you're stuck in that building all morning."

David offered a sharp, agreeable grunt. Even after his bowl of cereal at home, a warm breakfast sandwich and a hashbrown sounded perfect to anchor his stomach before the sensory overload of a new campus set in.

As they idled in the drive-thru lane, the scent of hot grease and coffee filling the van, David's gaze drifted toward his lap. His hands tightened slightly against his legs. The excitement of his first day was warring with the heavy, persistent ache of missing Hannah. During high school, she had always been his safe harbor in chaotic school environments. Facing a massive college building without her sitting next to him felt incredibly isolating.

His dad handed the cashier a few bills, grabbed the paper bag, and passed it over to the center console before glancing at David. The older man possessed the same hyper-observant radar as the twins.

"I know it's hard, Player Two," his dad said softly, putting the van back into gear. "But she's going to be so proud of you today. And remember, you'll talk to her tonight. Hawaii is six hours behind us. By the time you get home and decompress, she'll be waking up for her day, and you can tell her all about yours."

David tapped a quick, rhythmic acknowledgment against his thigh, his posture relaxing just a fraction. His dad was right. Their emotional bond remained entirely intact, easily surviving the 4,800 miles between Virginia and Pearl Harbor.

The van navigated the final few blocks, eventually pulling to a stop at the curb right outside the front entrance of the CCHR Martin Building.

“Alright, we’re here,” his dad said, putting the van in park and moving to unhook the wheelchair restraints in the back. He pulled his wallet from his pocket, extracted a crisp twenty-dollar bill, and tucked it securely into the side pocket of David’s bag. “For lunch later. Treat yourself at the mall across the street.”

David gave his dad a firm nod, gripping the friction tape on the handrims of his chair.

“Head straight up to the third-floor student lounge,” his dad instructed, stepping back so the van’s mechanical ramp could deploy. “You’ve got plenty of time before your eleven o’clock class. Find a quiet table, pull out your laptop, and turn it on. The second that screen boots up, you’re going to see that picture of you and Hannah from her visit this summer. Let her ground you before the day starts, okay?”

David smiled, a genuine, unshielded expression. He wheeled himself down the ramp and onto the downtown pavement, ready to face the overwhelming environment of the college campus, knowing exactly whose face was waiting for him behind the glass of his screen.

Scene 3: The Walker Building Lounge

The automatic doors of the Walker Building slid open, welcoming David into the blissfully air-conditioned lobby. He gripped the handrims of his manual chair and navigated toward the elevator bank, the friction tape steadying his hold. He pressed the up button, waited for the familiar mechanical *ding*, and rolled inside, hitting the button for the third floor.

When the doors parted again, David wheeled out and took an immediate right, heading down the quiet corridor toward the restrooms to handle his morning business. Once finished, he pivoted the chair and rolled back down the full length of the hallway. He passed the elevator bank he had just come from and continued to the very end of the corridor, turning right into the student lounge.

It was completely empty. The quiet hum of the fluorescent lights was the only sound in the room, creating a perfect, low-sensory environment.

David found a table near an electrical outlet and parked his chair. He pulled the warm, grease-spotted paper bag from his backpack and took his time eating his Rocket Burger breakfast sandwich and hashbrown. The food settled his stomach, grounding him in the morning routine. Once he finished and wiped his hands, he pulled his laptop from his bag, set it squarely on the table, and hit the power button.

The screen flickered to life, loading his desktop. David felt an immediate, involuntary smile pull at the corners of his mouth. The wallpaper was a high-resolution scan of the photo Meredith had taken over the summer. Hannah was standing behind his wheelchair, her arms wrapped fiercely over his shoulders, her

chin resting near his. They were both beaming. Staring at it, the overwhelming reality of the massive college campus outside the windows felt a little more manageable.

He clicked the mouse and launched Quantum Suite WritePad. The stark white document window snapped open, maximizing across the entire screen and completely covering Hannah's face.

David stretched his fingers and began jotting down a few preparatory notes. He typed out the name of his first class: *SDV 100 - Student Development*. He knew it was quite literally an introduction to college—a course designed to teach freshmen how to study, how to use the library, and how to survive higher education. He wanted to be ready.

A few minutes later, the sound of footsteps echoed in the hallway.

A girl walked into the lounge, a heavy backpack slung casually over one shoulder. She paused, glancing around the empty tables before her eyes landed on David. She offered a bright, easy smile and walked directly over to his table.

"Hey," she said, her voice friendly and conversational. "Do you mind if I join you? The tables downstairs are freezing, and it's practically a ghost town up here."

David offered a sharp, rhythmic tap on the table—his affirmative cue—and gestured toward the empty chair across from him. It was nice to have some company. Sitting alone in a silent room was peaceful, but having someone to pass the time with before his first-ever college class felt like a quintessential freshman experience.

"Thanks," she said, dropping her bag and pulling out the chair. "I'm Vesper."

David rested his hands on his laptop keyboard. He opened a new, blank WritePad document, quickly typed a response, and swiveled the laptop a few inches toward her so she could read the screen.

Hi Vesper. I'm David. It's my first day at CCHR.

Vesper read the screen, her brow furrowing slightly in polite confusion. She looked back up at him. "Nice to meet you, David. How come you're typing? Did you lose your voice?"

David didn't mind the question; people usually asked when they realized he wasn't going to speak. He pulled the laptop back slightly and typed again.

I have cerebral palsy. I can't speak verbally.

He turned the screen back to her. Vesper read it, her expression smoothing out into an easy, understanding nod. "Oh, gotcha," she said, leaning forward and resting her elbows on the table, completely unfazed. "Well, you type really fast, so that works perfectly. First day, huh? What class are you waiting for?"

SDV 100, David typed. *It's in the Martin Building at 11:00.*

Vesper's eyes lit up with genuine surprise. "No way. I'm in the Martin Building at 11:00 too. I'm taking Applied Calculus right next door to the SDV rooms."

David raised an eyebrow, his fingers flying across the keys. *Calculus doesn't sound like an easy morning class.*

Vesper laughed, a light, airy sound. "It is if you like numbers. I'm just taking it for an easy A, honestly. Math has always kind of been my thing." She checked the clock on the wall. "Since we're heading to the exact same place at the exact same time, I can walk over with you later, if you want?"

David nodded, offering a small smile. His literal, pragmatic brain processed the interaction exactly as it was presented: a fellow student waiting for class, making polite conversation, and offering to walk to the same building. It was a perfectly normal, pleasant start to his college career.

Scene 4: The InfoLink Update

For the next hour, the conversation flowed easily. Vesper proved to be incredibly talkative, which suited David perfectly. He didn't have to strain to keep the interaction going; he simply listened, nodded, and occasionally typed brief responses into his open Quantum Suite WritePad document to answer her questions.

She asked about his schedule, and he typed out his plan for the afternoon. *I'm going to The Promenade at Granby after class. My dad gave me twenty dollars for a burger combo at the food court.*

Vesper's face lit up. "Oh, I love the mall food court. I actually have a huge gap between my calculus class and my afternoon lab. Do you mind if I tag along? I'd love to grab lunch with you."

David offered a sharp, agreeable grunt and typed, *Sure. That sounds great.* His literal processing cataloged the interaction cleanly: he was going to eat lunch, and she also needed to eat lunch. It made logical sense to go together.

A familiar, high-pitched chime suddenly echoed from his laptop speakers. David minimized the WritePad window just enough to reveal the buddy list of InfoLink Messenger, keeping the main document stretched over the background photo of Hannah so he wouldn't accidentally close it. He saw Morgan's screenname highlighted in bright green, signaling she was online.

He opened a chat box and began typing rapidly.

Dave: Hey. Made it to campus. Sitting in the lounge.

Morg: Awesome! How is it? Overwhelming?

Dave: It's quiet. I met a girl named Vesper. She has a math class next to my SDV class. We're going to get lunch at the mall after.

Vesper leaned over slightly, looking at the chat window. "Who are you messaging?"

David pointed to the screen and typed a quick explanation in WritePad. *My cousin, Morgan. We live together.*

"Oh, that's sweet," Vesper smiled, leaning back in her chair.

On the screen, Morgan's reply popped up.

Morg: That's great! Make sure you get a good burger. Just remember Mer is picking you up at the mall entrance at 2:00 PM. I gotta run, leaving for the salon now. Wish me luck getting this dark box dye stripped out! Going back to blonde so Mer and I can play Twin Magic.

David smiled at the screen, double-blinking in amusement at his cousin's tactical plans before typing a quick goodbye. He closed the InfoLink window just as the digital clock in the corner of his screen rolled over to 10:45 AM.

He tapped the table to get Vesper's attention, pointing to the time.

"Oh, wow, you're right. We should head over," Vesper said, standing up and slinging her backpack over her shoulder. As David reached for the friction tape on his wheelchair's handrims, Vesper stepped behind him. "Here, let me. The brick sidewalk outside can be a pain. I don't mind."

David paused, but then gave a short hum of appreciation, relaxing his grip. He was perfectly capable of pushing himself, but it was a warm morning, and saving his energy before his first class was a welcome luxury. He let her take the heavy rubber grips of the push handles.

Vesper navigated the chair with surprising ease, pushing him out of the lounge, into the Walker Building elevator, and down to the ground floor. They rolled out into the humid Virginia air, crossing the single city block until the imposing brick facade of the Martin Building loomed ahead of them.

Vesper pushed him through the automated doors and directly into the main elevator bank, hitting the button for the fourth floor. When the doors opened, the hallway was a chaotic, buzzing hive of freshmen trying to find their rooms.

Vesper pushed him down the corridor until they reached the door for SDV 100. Right next door, the plaque for the 200-level Applied Calculus room gleamed under the fluorescent lights.

"Alright, here we are," Vesper said, stepping around to the front of his chair with a bright smile. "Have a great first class, David. I'll meet you right out here when it's over, and we'll head across the street for those burgers."

David nodded, offering a warm smile and a polite wave as she turned and walked into the math classroom. He gripped his wheels and rolled himself into SDV 100, feeling incredibly accomplished. His first college interaction was a complete success, and he hadn't even opened a textbook yet.

Scene 5: The Color Correction

The chemical smell of the strip mall salon hit the twins the second they walked through the glass doors. It was a potent, sterile mix of aerosol hairspray, burning flat irons, and sharp ammonia. Morgan checked in at the reception desk, with Meredith standing shoulder-to-shoulder right beside her.

Ten minutes later, Morgan was sitting in a black vinyl styling chair with a heavy nylon cape draped over her shoulders, while Meredith claimed the station right next to hers.

Their stylist, an older woman named Tracy with heavily highlighted hair and a pragmatist's gaze, stood behind Morgan. Tracy ran her fingers through Morgan's waist-length, dark brunette hair, lifting the heavy sections and inspecting the half-inch band of natural, sun-kissed ash roots at the scalp.

"So," Tracy said, catching Morgan's eye in the massive wall mirror. "You want to go back to your natural blonde. How long have you been dyeing it dark?"

"A little over a year," Morgan replied, leaning back into the chair. "I just touch up the roots every month. But I'm done. I want it perfectly matched to my sister's."

Tracy looked over at Meredith. Meredith calmly reached back, pulled her signature plastic claw clip loose, and let her own waist-length, natural sun-kissed ash hair cascade down her back.

"That's the target," Meredith said cleanly, her "Ice" protocol operating even in a salon setting. "Since we're identical, her underlying pigment is exactly the same as mine. I'm just here to serve as the physical color swatch."

Tracy let out a heavy sigh, dropping Morgan's hair and resting her hands on her hips. "Honey, I'm going to be straight with you. You both have gorgeous, healthy hair, but permanent dark dye is stubborn. It stains the cuticle."

"I know," Morgan nodded, having done her homework the night before. "I read that color doesn't lift color. You can't just slap blonde dye over the brunette and call it a day, right?"

Tracy raised a genuinely impressed eyebrow. "Exactly. We have to strip it, and it is going to be a massive project. You're going to be in my chair for the next five hours. First, I have to apply a chemical color reducer to pull the artificial brunette molecules out. Fair warning: it smells exactly like rotten eggs. After we wash that out, your hair is going to look like a rusty penny. Then, I have to go in with bleach to lift you past that orange stage. Finally, we tone it back to match your sister's."

"What about the damage?" Meredith asked, her eyes narrowing slightly in the mirror.

"We'll take it slow," Tracy assured her. "But it's going to cost a pretty penny, and your scalp is going to tingle."

Morgan stared at her reflection, imagining Vesper Vance. She pictured the inevitable moment someone tried to corner David or Kate, thinking they had outsmarted Meredith, only to realize the "Fire" protocol was standing right behind them, wearing the exact same face. The psychological warfare of Twin Magic was unparalleled.

"Do it," Morgan said, her voice entirely devoid of hesitation. "Strip it. Whatever it takes to get it perfectly matched."

Tracy chuckled, shaking her head as she turned toward the chemical mixing room in the back. "Alright, boss. Get comfortable. I'll go mix up the sulfur."

While Tracy was mixing the color stripper, another stylist gestured for Meredith to move into her chair. Since she was already there, Meredith requested her standard maintenance—a thorough wash and a clean trim to dust the dead ends off her waist-length hair.

Morgan watched her sister in the mirror. “You don’t have to stay for the rotten egg part, Mer. It’s going to reek.”

“I’m not going anywhere until I have to leave to pick David up at two,” Meredith replied calmly, leaning her head back into the ceramic washbowl. “We’re in this together. Plus, if Tracy gets the toner wrong, I need to be here to hold up a lock of my hair and object.”

Morgan smiled, settling deeper into the vinyl chair. The perimeter was secure, David was safe in his SDV 100 class, and the twins were preparing to rebuild their ultimate visual weapon.

Scene 6: SDV 100

David rolled through the doorway of the Martin Building classroom, his tires gliding smoothly over the linoleum floor. He scanned the room, his analytical mind immediately taking inventory. The classroom was designed to hold thirty students, but it felt remarkably empty. There were only nine other students scattered across the rows, and as David navigated toward the front, he realized he was the only male in the room.

He parked his manual chair at the designated wheelchair-accessible table near the front. He looked at the standard student desks arrayed behind him—rigid plastic chairs bolted directly to tiny, restrictive laminate tabletops. They looked incredibly uncomfortable. He felt a wave of relief that his physical mobility needs afforded him a wide, freestanding table where he could comfortably set up his laptop and angle his heavy OmniTalk 3000.

At eleven o’clock, the female instructor, Professor Hayes, walked to the front of the room. She spent the first twenty minutes handing out syllabi, explaining the attendance policy, and outlining the purpose of Student Development 100 as the foundational survival guide for college.

“Now,” Professor Hayes said, clapping her hands together. “Since this is a small group, we are going to do an icebreaker. Let’s go around the room with ‘Three Truths and a Lie.’ You’ll give us four facts about yourself, and the rest of the class has to guess which one you made up.”

She pointed to the front row. “Let’s start over here.”

The game moved systematically around the room, forcing the quiet students to introduce themselves.

The first was a white Caucasian exchange student named Chloe. She leaned back, dropping her backpack onto the floor. A prominent Union Jack patch was pinned to the front pocket.

“Right then,” Chloe said, her voice carrying a thick, unmistakable Cockney accent. “One: I’m absolutely terrified of spiders. Two: I play ice hockey. Three: I put maple syrup in my morning tea. And four: I walk past the Queen’s guards at Buckingham Palace on my way to my hometown school.”

The class, completely thrown by her heavy British accent and the flag on her bag, immediately assumed the Canadian stereotypes had to be fake.

“It’s the maple syrup,” Jessica guessed confidently. “You definitely don’t put syrup in tea.”

Chloe laughed, her Cockney lilt still perfectly intact. “No, the Buckingham Palace one is the lie. My parents are from East London and I picked up their accent at home, but I was born and raised in London, Ontario. Everyone always falls for the accent.”

The girl sitting next to her, Geneviève, was also a Canadian exchange student. She spoke with a beautifully clear cadence, effortlessly weaving perfect Canadian English with a flawless Québécois French accent. “One: I speak French at home. Two: I drove from Saint-Georges, Québec, to Virginia. Three: I love eating poutine. Four: I go snowboarding every single weekend.”

The class guessed correctly—her lie was snowboarding, as she actually hated the cold weather despite living in Canada.

Next was Emily, a girl with a completely American-sounding name but deep, traditional Asian cultural heritage. “One: My grandparents own a traditional Japanese restaurant. Two: I know how to perform a full tea ceremony. Three: I have a black belt in judo. Four: I was born in Tokyo.”

Her lie was the birthplace; she had actually been born in California.

The next three students were African American girls sitting in a loose cluster.

Jasmine went first. “One: I work at a veterinary clinic. Two: I have five sisters. Three: I make my own jewelry. Four: I have a pet iguana.” Her lie was the iguana, drawing a few laughs from the room.

Kiara sat up straight for her turn. “One: I sing in my church choir. Two: I can do a standing backflip. Three: I love reading classic horror novels. Four: I’ve never broken a single bone.” The class accurately guessed that the backflip was a lie.

Maya leaned forward, resting her elbows on the uncomfortable bolted desk. “One: I run track. Two: I am double-jointed in my thumbs. Three: I bake wedding cakes with my mom. Four: I absolutely love scary movies.” Her lie was the horror movies; she admitted she couldn’t even watch commercials for them without getting nightmares.

Next was Nia. She gripped the edge of her tiny desk, her knuckles slightly white. She was Jamaican, and her thick accent was laced with visible nerves. “One: This is my very first time in the United States. Two: I grew up five minutes from the beach. Three: I love spicy jerk chicken. Four: I am a competitive ice skater.”

Her lie was incredibly obvious, but her nervous delivery made the room smile warmly. David caught her eye and offered a slow, supportive double-blink. Nia seemed to relax just a fraction, realizing the classroom was a safe space.

Before anyone could answer, Kiara chimed in with a grin. “Wait, you’re not a bobsledder, are you? You know, feeling the rhythm, feeling the rhyme?”

Nia let out a bright, genuine laugh, the tension completely leaving her shoulders. “No bobsledding for me, I promise! The ice skating is definitely the lie.”

The last two women in the back row were Caucasian Americans.

Sarah spoke up. “One: I drive a manual transmission car. Two: I am highly allergic to strawberries. Three: I play the acoustic guitar. Four: I met the President of the United States.”

The class collectively murmured, and almost every student pointed to the fourth option.

Sarah smirked, shaking her head. “Nope. I actually met him years ago when he was still the Governor of Arkansas. Shook his hand at a rally. The lie is the acoustic guitar. I have absolutely zero musical talent.”

Jessica went next. “One: I have a twin brother. Two: I work at a used bookstore. Three: I own a horse. Four: I speak fluent German.” Her lie was the German fluency, admitting she barely passed high school Spanish.

Then, the room went quiet. Every eye turned toward the accessible table at the front.

David didn’t panic. He was perfectly comfortable with who he was, and he knew exactly how to establish his boundaries. He stretched his fingers, pulling his laptop closer, and typed his four facts directly into the open Quantum Suite WritePad document. Rather than turning the screen, he highlighted the text and routed it through the OmniTalk 3000 clamped to his chair. The device required firm physical pressure on its resistive touch screen, but it was necessary for the room to hear him clearly.

The heavy, robotic voice echoed through the quiet classroom.

“One. I communicate fluently using my own system of non-verbal hums and taps. Two. I share a house with fiercely protective identical twin cousins. Three. I am currently taking lessons to get my driver’s license. Four. I rely on this device to speak to new people.”

The class looked at him, mentally weighing the options. Geneviève tentatively raised her hand. “Is the lie number three? About the driver’s license?”

David smiled, a sharp, unshielded grin. He tapped his keyboard, letting the robotic voice confirm it.

“Correct. My cerebral palsy affects my fine motor control, making driving impossible. Number three is the lie.”

A ripple of warm, respectful nods moved through the nine women in the room. Professor Hayes smiled, marking a check on her roster. David leaned back in his manual chair, feeling his muscles relax. SDV 100 was going to be an easy class.

Scene 7: The Foundation

With the icebreaker finished and the tension in the room thoroughly dissolved, Professor Hayes moved to the dry-erase board at the front of the classroom.

“Alright, let’s talk about why you are all actually here,” she began, uncapping a marker. “Student Development 100 is a mandatory class for a reason. Right now, you are all standing on the bridge between high school and the rest of your lives. And the biggest shock you are going to face this semester is the sudden, absolute freedom.”

David focused on his screen, his fingers resting lightly on his laptop keyboard. He had a fresh Quantum Suite WritePad document open, ready to take notes.

“In high school, you had guardrails,” Professor Hayes explained, pacing slowly across the front of the room. “You had teachers chasing you down for missing assignments. You had parents getting progress reports. You had a rigid, bell-to-bell schedule. Here at CCHR, all of that is gone. You are officially adults. If you skip class, no one is going to call your house. If you don’t turn in a paper, I am not going to remind you. Your syllabus is your contract, and time management is entirely your responsibility.”

David typed the words *Time Management* and *Self-Advocacy* into his document. He felt a profound sense of validation washing over him. For his entire life, his schedule had been dictated by Individualized Education Programs, physical therapy appointments, and the deeply loving but unyielding protective perimeter of the Delaney Vanguard. Hearing a professor explicitly state that he was an adult responsible for his own success was exhilarating. It was the exact autonomy his father and cousins had promised him this morning.

For the next half hour, Professor Hayes walked them through the survival mechanics of the Norfolk campus. She handed out detailed maps, circling the library in the Walker Building, the academic advising offices, and the campus tutoring center.

“Self-advocacy is your greatest tool,” she emphasized, making eye contact with the students. “If you are struggling in a class, do not wait until midterms. The tutoring center is free. My office hours are on the syllabus. You have to be the one to raise your hand and ask for help, because no one here is going to read your mind.”

David saved his WritePad document, intentionally leaving the window maximized across his screen. He didn’t want to close it, knowing he would need to type out his lunch order when he got to the mall anyway. He simply closed the laptop lid, letting the machine slip into sleep mode, and slid it safely into his backpack.

“Alright, that covers the ground rules,” Professor Hayes announced as the digital clock on the wall clicked over to 11:50 AM. “Read the first two chapters of the textbook by Wednesday. Welcome to college, everyone. You’re dismissed.”

The classroom instantly filled with the chaotic sound of chairs scraping against the linoleum and backpacks zipping shut. David gripped the friction tape on his wheelchair's handrims, navigating his way out from behind the accessible table. He offered a polite nod to Nia and Geneviève as he rolled toward the door, merging with the flow of students heading out into the fourth-floor corridor.

The hallway was a sudden explosion of noise as dozens of classroom doors opened simultaneously. David wheeled himself out of SDV 100, letting his eyes adjust to the fluorescent lights of the hallway.

Right next door, the heavy wooden door to the 200-level Applied Calculus room swung open.

Vesper Vance stepped out into the hallway, her backpack slung casually over her shoulder. She scanned the crowd for a fraction of a second before her eyes locked onto David's wheelchair. The bright, easy smile from the student lounge instantly returned to her face. She walked smoothly through the flow of exiting students, slipping right into his personal space.

"Hey," Vesper said, her voice easily cutting through the noise of the hallway. She looked down at him, her demeanor perfectly charming and thoroughly convincing. "Surviving so far?"

David gave a sharp, affirmative grunt, offering a warm smile.

"Good," she said, gesturing down the long corridor toward the main elevator bank. "My calculus professor spent fifty minutes talking about derivatives. My brain is officially fried. Are you ready to go get those burgers?"

Scene 8: The Promenade at Granby

The transition from the academic quiet of the classroom to the humid Norfolk air was abrupt. Vesper easily took control of the heavy rubber push handles of David's manual wheelchair, steering him out the front doors of the Martin Building. They took a right on the sidewalk, took another right into the open brick plaza, and navigated the single city block over to Monticello Avenue. After waiting for the crosswalk light, Vesper pushed him across the wide street and through the main glass entrance of The Promenade at Granby.

The blast of mall air conditioning was a welcome relief, but the noise was immediate. David had been to the upscale downtown mall plenty of times, and as they entered the main corridor, he let out a low, frustrated groan. The line for the central court elevators—Elevators M2, M3, and M4—was a massive, chaotic bottleneck of hungry office workers and college students.

He wasn't going to wait in that sensory nightmare. David reached down, his hands gripping the friction tape on the push rims of his wheels. He took the reins of his chair back from Vesper and immediately pivoted to the right, heading away from the crowd and wheeling himself purposefully toward Norwood's.

"Wait, where are you going?" Vesper asked, jogging a few steps to catch up with him. "The food court is on the third floor. Those elevators are right there."

David didn't stop. He knew the layout of this mall perfectly, and he knew that Elevator M1 was tucked quietly into a far corner near the department store. Vesper let out a soft complaint about how far they were walking, but David took the lead, pushing himself down the quiet corridor until the brushed metal doors of Elevator M1 appeared on their left. He reached out and pressed the call button.

While they waited, his mind shifted to his lunch options. A flame-broiled burger and fries from Crown Burger sounded exactly like what he needed.

The *ding* echoed in the quiet corner, and the doors slid open. David wheeled himself into the empty elevator. It was a unique cab—tall, rectangular glass panels were set directly into the center of the brushed steel doors, allowing passengers to look out into the atrium. Vesper stepped in behind him. He pressed the button for the third floor, and the heavy doors slid shut, sealing them inside.

As the hydraulic lift engaged and the elevator began its ascent, David looked out through the glass door panels, watching the atrium of the first floor drop away.

"Okay, so here's the deal," Vesper said suddenly. The light, charming tone she had used in the lounge was completely gone. Her voice was sharp, flat, and aggressively loud in the enclosed space. "We *will* be eating from the value menu today."

David blinked, his autistic brain struggling to process the sudden, jarring shift in volume and tone. She was practically screaming at him. His literal processing kicked in: she must be worried about how much money they had. He quickly reached into his pocket, pulled out his wallet, and extracted the crisp twenty-dollar bill his dad had given him that morning. He held it up, pointing to the cash and then tapping his own chest, trying to communicate non-verbally that he had his own money and could pay for himself.

Vesper's eyes narrowed into a glare. She completely failed to understand his communication, misinterpreting his literal gesture as a defiant challenge to her authority. She let out a sharp, angry scoff, her posture rigid and hostile.

David quickly folded the twenty and shoved it back into his pocket, a spike of sensory anxiety hitting his chest. He was deeply unnerved. Why had she just screamed at him over lunch prices?

As the hydraulic lift pushed past the second floor, the concrete lip of the third-floor landing slowly came into view through the glass panels of the elevator doors. And standing right there on the landing, perfectly framed in the glass before the elevator even leveled out, was Meredith.

David didn't hesitate. The second the doors parted, he gripped his wheels, propelled himself forward out of the cab, and practically threw his arms around Meredith's waist. Meredith dropped her shopping bag instantly and wrapped her arms around his shoulders, pulling him into a fierce, heavy hug. The familiar Deep Pressure Therapy instantly regulated his spiking heart rate.

Vesper stepped out of the elevator, her jaw dropping slightly in confusion. Her eyes immediately tracked over Meredith, taking in her thick glasses, her casual striped shirt, and her disproportionately large chest.

David pulled back from the hug. He flipped his laptop open on his lap, bringing up the WritePad document, and typed quickly before routing it through the heavy OmniTalk 3000 clamped to his chair.

“Meredith, this is Vesper. She is in the math class next door to SDV,” the robotic voice announced, completely devoid of emotion. “Vesper, this is my cousin, Meredith. We are getting lunch. Meredith, would you like to join us?”

Vesper’s face instantly twisted into a look of dark, heavy skepticism. *Cousin.* Vesper’s eyes darted between David and this striking, waist-length-haired woman. The look she shot David made it abundantly clear she didn’t buy the family connection for a single second, and that having this girl crash their lunch was a terrible idea. David, entirely focused on his OmniTalk screen, missed the judgmental glare completely.

But Meredith didn’t. She noticed every single micro-expression.

As the device spoke, David locked eyes with Meredith. He offered a very specific, tense double-blink. *Be my bodyguard.* He didn’t know Vesper well enough to know if she was a good person, but the screaming in the elevator had set off every alarm bell in his head.

Meredith’s “Ice” protocol engaged instantly. She read David’s tension, smoothly picked up her shopping bag, and offered Vesper a polite, chillingly perfect smile. “I’d love to.”

Vesper groaned quietly under her breath, a flash of deep irritation crossing her face, but she forced a tight smile and went along with it.

They navigated to the Crown Burger counter. David pulled out his twenty-dollar bill, pointing to Meredith’s tray and offering to treat her. Meredith accepted with a warm smile, but her eyes flicked over David’s shoulder. She caught the perturbed look on Vesper’s face—a look of absolute jealousy, confirming her assumption that Vesper believed David was wasting his money on another woman.

They found a table in the food court. David ate his burger, typing a quick question into WritePad.

“Where is Morgan?” the OmniTalk 3000 asked.

“She’s still at the salon getting her hair dye removed,” Meredith answered casually, taking a sip of her drink. She was very careful to only use her sister’s name, deliberately hiding the fact that Morgan was her identical twin from the stranger sitting across the table.

Vesper picked at her value-menu fries, clearly annoyed that David was focusing all of his attention and communication on his “cousin” rather than her. Meredith silently cataloged Vesper’s irritation, letting the silence stretch until the older girl grew visibly uncomfortable.

When the last fry was eaten, Meredith stood up, brushing off her jeans. She turned to Vesper with a tone that was flawlessly polite but left absolutely no room for debate. “Well, it was nice to meet you, Vesper. But it’s time for David and me to go home.”

Vesper offered a stiff goodbye, clearly frustrated by the loss of control, and turned to walk back toward the academic buildings.

The moment Vesper was out of earshot, Meredith's posture softened. She stepped behind David's chair, resting her hands gently on his shoulders. "I didn't like her," Meredith said quietly. "I was highly uncomfortable with how she reacted when you hugged me. And I didn't like the way she was looking at you."

David let out a long, exhausted sigh.

"Hey," Meredith said, leaning down to catch his eye with a warm smile. "Good news. You get to call Hannah tonight. Let's get you home so you can decompress. We just need to swing by the salon in Virginia Beach to pick up Morgan, and then we're back on Delaney Street. Sound good?"

David tapped his handrims in sharp, grateful agreement. He let Meredith take the push handles, completely surrendering navigation to her. She steered him through the mall and out to the South Parking Deck.

As they rolled out onto the concrete of the garage, the automated mall PA system chimed overhead.

"Welcome to The Promenade at Granby. This is your Personal Reminder Service. Please remember that you parked on the South Deck, Level 3. That's South, Level 3. Have a wonderful shopping experience."

Meredith navigated them to Level S4, where her sedan was parked. She opened the passenger door and expertly assisted David with the mechanical transfer from his wheelchair into the front seat. Once he was buckled in, she collapsed the manual chair and stowed it securely in the trunk.

She climbed into the driver's seat, engaged the clutch, and smoothly shifted the manual transmission into first gear. They spiraled down to the ground floor, where Meredith paid the parking attendant. She pulled out of the garage, took a left onto City Hall Ave, and merged onto I-264 East, putting the concrete sprawl of downtown Norfolk in the rearview mirror as they headed back to the safety of the Vanguard.

Scene 9: The Debrief

The interior of Meredith's practical sedan was cool and quiet, the low hum of the tires on the asphalt serving as a comforting white noise. They were cruising down I-264 East, leaving the concrete towers of downtown Norfolk behind them.

David had his compact travel keyboard resting comfortably on his lap, tethered to the OmniTalk 3000 system. He didn't need to hit the audio trigger right away; he typed out his thoughts in a steady rhythm, letting the sentences queue up while Meredith kept her eyes on the road, her right hand resting lightly on the manual gear shift.

"Okay, hit me," Meredith said, glancing at the rearview mirror. "What exactly happened between the lounge and the third floor?"

David pressed the trigger. The heavy, robotic voice filled the cabin.

“She seemed nice in the lounge,” the device stated. “The thought of having lunch with someone was nice. But the central court elevators were packed. I knew Elevator M1 at Norwood’s would be empty. She complained about the walk.”

Meredith let out a sharp chuckle, downshifting smoothly as traffic slowed slightly. “I had the exact same idea. I was on the third floor and didn’t want to deal with the M2 crowd, so I went to the Norwood’s corner to catch M1 down. Great minds.”

David typed his next sentence, his fingers moving a little faster as the frustration of the memory returned.

“When we got inside the glass, she suddenly changed her attitude. She screamed at me that we were eating the value menu. I pulled out the twenty dollars Dad gave me to show I could pay. She got angrier.”

Meredith’s jaw tightened, the brief humor vanishing entirely. Her “Ice” protocol was deeply sensitive to people who raised their voices at her cousin. “She screamed at you? In a closed elevator?”

“Yes,” the robotic voice answered. “I do not wish to get to know Vesper any further. Can you or Morgan accompany me on Wednesday? So I am not alone.”

“Absolutely,” Meredith said without a second of hesitation. They were approaching Exit 14A. Meredith pressed the clutch and downshifted, slowing the sedan to take the sweeping ramp for I-64 Eastbound toward Chesapeake. “We’ll both come. We can bring Kate, too. Make it a full Vanguard escort.”

David’s eyes lit up. A sharp, breathy giggle escaped him. He began typing furiously, a massive, unshielded grin spreading across his face.

“If she bothers us, we can deploy the Poop Button.”

Meredith burst out laughing as she merged the sedan onto I-64. The “Poop Button” was their ultimate, undefeated psychological operation. Meredith and Morgan were not fighters, and they never threatened physical violence; instead, they engaged in advanced, utterly absurd biological warfare to protect their perimeter.

“Oh, Vesper would absolutely shatter,” Meredith laughed, accelerating over the Twin Bridges into Virginia Beach. “Can you imagine? I’d tell her it’s an industrial, military-grade model. Then I’d look at Kate’s urine bag and tell Vesper she’s standing in the splash zone.”

David slapped his knee, shaking with silent laughter. The best part of the strategy was always Kate herself. Kate never lied, but she never helped the predator, either. She would just sit in her manual wheelchair, technically honest, while the twins escalated the horror.

“She’d ask Kate if it can actually spray,” Meredith continued, wiping a tear of mirth from her eye as she took Exit 286B, looping onto Indian River Road Eastbound. “And Kate would just say, *‘It’s related to bowel management,’* and Vesper would run away thinking we hold certifications in advanced bowel warfare.”

They were both laughing their asses off as the tension of the afternoon completely evaporated. The threat of Vesper Vance felt microscopic compared to the unified front of the cousins.

A few minutes later, Meredith pulled the sedan into the Kemps River shopping center, parking near the glass storefront of Tracy's hair salon.

Meredith killed the engine and turned to David, her tone shifting back to practical caregiving. "Okay, so before we go in, I need to warn you. Morgan is about an hour and a half into a five-hour color correction. You know how she wanted to go back to being blonde so we can run Twin Magic again?"

David offered a sharp, affirmative grunt.

"Right. Well, Tracy had to use a chemical color stripper first. It smelled like straight rotten eggs," Meredith explained, wrinkling her nose. "Right now, Morgan is sitting in the chair with bleach on her head. Her hair is going to look like a rusty penny. It's going to be bright, brassy orange."

David double-blinked, a fresh wave of amusement hitting him.

"Don't laugh at her," Meredith warned, though she was smiling. "She's suffering for the cause. Tracy still has to tone it back to my exact shade of ash. But by tonight, the Vanguard will be back to full, identical strength. Ready to go secure the perimeter?"

David nodded enthusiastically. He was ready to get Morgan, get home, and count down the hours until he could log onto InfoLink Messenger to tell Hannah about the absolute disaster of his first college lunch.

Scene 10: The Salon Debrief

The moment David and Meredith pushed through the glass doors of Tracy's salon, a wall of putrid, sulfurous air hit them. True to Meredith's warning, the chemical color stripper smelled exactly like rotten eggs. David wrinkled his nose, but he gripped the handrims of his manual wheelchair and pushed forward, determined to power through the stench for Morgan's sake.

They found Morgan sitting in Tracy's chair in the back of the shop. The dark brunette dye was completely gone. In its place, Morgan's heavy, waist-length hair was a shocking, brassy shade of rusty orange.

"Don't say a word," Morgan warned, glaring at Meredith through the reflection in the massive wall mirror. "Tracy is mixing the bleach right now."

David let out a sharp, breathy giggle, wheeling himself directly into the spot next to her styling chair. Meredith pulled up a rolling stool and sat close to David, allowing him to lean his weight heavily against her shoulder. The firm, continuous physical contact provided the grounding Deep Pressure Therapy he needed to offset the sensory nightmare of the salon's chemical odors.

"So, how was the first day?" Morgan asked, wincing slightly as Tracy returned and began painting cold bleach onto her orange strands. "Did the SDV class survive you?"

David flipped his laptop open, resting it on his lap, and quickly typed out his response into WritePad before routing it through the OmniTalk 3000.

“The class was great,” the robotic voice echoed over the hum of the salon’s blow dryers. “There are only ten students. I am the only guy in a room with nine women.”

Morgan laughed. “Oh, you’ll be perfectly fine. You were raised in a house completely overrun by women anyway.”

David double-blinked in agreement. Living with his mother, Meredith, Morgan, Kate, and having Hannah essentially move in during her father’s Diego Garcia deployment meant he was entirely comfortable in female-dominated spaces.

“The mall, however, was a different story,” Meredith chimed in, leaning her head against David’s. “Tell her about your new friend.”

David’s fingers flew across the keyboard. He gave Morgan a flawless, pragmatic breakdown of his encounter with Vesper Vance. He explained the polite conversation in the student lounge, the walk across the street, the decision to use Elevator M1 to avoid the crowds, and the sudden, jarring moment Vesper screamed at him about the value menu.

Morgan’s eyes narrowed in the mirror, her “Fire” protocol instantly flaring to life. She didn’t hesitate for a single second.

“We are coming with you on Wednesday,” Morgan declared, her tone deadly serious despite the foil packets jutting out of her hair. “We’ll bring Kate. If this Vesper girl even looks at you wrong, we are deploying the Poop Button.”

Meredith burst into laughter, and David slapped his knee, his shoulders shaking with silent mirth.

“What?” Morgan demanded, looking between them.

“We literally just had the exact same conversation in the car,” Meredith wheezed, wiping her eyes. “I told him we’d threaten her with the splash zone.”

David offered a bright smile. It was a terrifyingly comforting reminder that the twins operated on the exact same protective wavelength.

Tracy, working the bleach through Morgan’s hair with practiced precision, chuckled from behind the styling chair. Having been the Delaney family’s cosmetologist for years, she was intimately familiar with their specific brand of psychological warfare. She knew perfectly well that Kate’s MACE was a legitimate medical device for bowel management, not an industrial poop launcher, but she completely supported the twins’ mythology.

“You know, David,” Tracy said, catching his eye in the mirror. “I see a lot of people sit in this chair, and I hear a lot of stories. A girl who acts sweet when it’s just the two of you, but snaps the second she thinks she’s losing control over a lunch order? That is a massive red flag. You’re making the right choice keeping her at arm’s length. She sounds like bad news.”

David tapped a rhythmic acknowledgment on his laptop case. Hearing it from Tracy was all the validation he needed. If the woman who handled the Vanguard’s hair thought someone was a threat, her judgment was as good as gold.

With the debrief complete, David settled deeper into Meredith's side, opening up his class portal to tackle his very first college assignment. Professor Hayes had assigned a "168-Hour Time Management Audit." He needed to map out exactly how he planned to spend every hour of the upcoming week—blocking out time for sleep, SDV 100, transportation, and homework.

As he diligently typed out his schedule, blocking off the evening hours specifically for his daily Link chats with Hannah, he felt a profound sense of peace. He sincerely hoped Vesper would just take the hint and leave him alone. He didn't *want* to subject a stranger to the horrifying, fictional capabilities of Kate's medical equipment.

But as he looked at Morgan's fierce reflection in the mirror, he knew the Vanguard was ready. Vesper seemed exactly like the kind of person who would push the boundary, just to find out if the twins were bluffing.

Scene 11: The Library Intercept

The five-hour marathon finally came to an end. Tracy turned off the blow dryer and spun Morgan's vinyl chair around to face the mirror.

Morgan stared at her reflection. The dark brunette was entirely gone, but the result wasn't the exact sun-kissed ash she was aiming for. Instead, her long hair was a bright, warm honey-caramel.

"That's as far as the chemistry will let us go today without completely frying your ends," Tracy explained, resting her hands on Morgan's shoulders. "We lifted a massive amount of artificial pigment, and I toned out the harsh orange, but your hair needs to rest. Give it a month, come back for Phase Two, and I can pull the rest of this warmth out so you perfectly match your sister."

Morgan ran her hands through the honey-colored strands, nodding pragmatically. "It's fine. It looks healthy. We'll deploy Twin Magic next month. The 'Fire' protocol still works as a redhead."

David wheeled himself forward, offering a sharp, happy hum as he reached out to hug both of his cousins. The salon ordeal was over, and the Vanguard was back in motion.

When they stepped out into the humid evening air and approached Meredith's sedan, David didn't head for the front passenger seat. He tapped the rear door. Meredith opened it, and David transferred into the back, pulling himself across the upholstery so he could sit directly next to Morgan. As Meredith stowed his chair and got behind the wheel, David leaned his full weight against Morgan, resting his head on her shoulder. Morgan wrapped her arm around him, letting him cuddle into her side, supplying the Deep Pressure Therapy he needed after a long, exhausting day in the public eye.

"Next stop, the city library," Meredith announced, shifting the car into gear. "Kate texted that her doctor's appointment wrapped up an hour ago and her dad dropped her off at the reading room to wait for us."

It was a short drive from the salon to the Virginia Beach public library. Meredith parked near the accessible ramp. She hopped out, and a few moments later, she returned with Kate, pushing her paternal cousin's manual wheelchair to the passenger side of the sedan.

Meredith opened the front door and expertly assisted Kate with the transfer. It was a fluid, highly practiced maneuver, shifting Kate from the chair to the car seat while carefully managing the tubing of her urinary collection bag so nothing snagged. Once Kate was buckled in, Meredith folded the second wheelchair, stowing it in the trunk next to David's.

As Meredith climbed into the driver's seat and started the engine, Morgan leaned forward from the back seat, resting her chin on the center console.

"Hey, Kate," Morgan said, a wicked grin spreading across her face. "Just a heads-up. On Wednesday, Meredith and I are going to escort David to his SDV 100 class. And we might need to deploy the Poop Button."

Kate slowly turned her head in the passenger seat. She locked eyes with Meredith, her face completely deadpan. She offered a ferocious, unblinking glare, staring absolute daggers at her cousin, pretending to be furious that they were once again weaponizing her bowel management system.

The tense silence held for exactly three seconds.

Then, Kate's shoulders began to shake. She completely broke character, her glare melting into a massive smile as she burst into a series of silent, breathy, uncontrollable giggles.

David squeezed Morgan's arm, laughing silently in the back seat. Kate tapped the dashboard twice—a specific, questioning rhythm they all recognized. *Who is the customer?*

"Her name is Vesper," Meredith explained, navigating the sedan out of the library parking lot. "She's in the class next door to David's. She tried to isolate him in an elevator at the mall today. She was screaming at him about a lunch order because she didn't realize he had his own money."

Morgan's tone darkened. "It was an isolation tactic. Just like what Connor tried to do."

At the mention of Connor's name, the laughter in the car instantly vanished. Kate's smile faded, replaced by a quiet, lingering sadness. She looked out the passenger window at the passing trees. Connor hadn't just *seemed* like a good guy—he genuinely was one. He had sat with her at lunch, treated her with respect, and they had shared a wonderful, typical high school romance. Because of her literal processing, she had fundamentally believed he cared about her, and he truly did. But then came the day his parents left town. He had thrown away their entire genuine connection for a sudden, impulsive, and terrible choice—a decision that ended with a stolen 1997 Holt sedan wrapped around a utility pole.

Now, her body was permanently altered, and a boy who used to hold her hand was rotting away in a Virginia state penitentiary.

Meredith reached across the center console, resting her hand gently on Kate's knee. "I know, Kate," she said softly. "I know. But Vesper tried to pull the same trick today. She tried to catch David alone because she thought he was an easy target. That's why we're shutting it down."

Kate turned back from the window. She looked at Meredith, then glanced back at David and Morgan, and gave a single, firm nod. The sadness was pushed aside, replaced by the unified, unyielding resolve of the Vanguard. If someone was threatening David, the Poop Button was officially authorized.

"Alright," Meredith said, turning onto Delaney Street, the familiar, comforting sight of their neighborhood coming into view. "Let's get inside. When the adults get home from work tonight, we need to have a full family briefing on Vesper Vance. David, you can relax until the long-distance rates drop at nine. Then, you can finally call Hannah."

Scene 12: The Family Briefing

The kitchen at 1854 Delaney Street was filled with the chaotic, comforting hum of the evening routine. The microwave beeped repeatedly as various containers of leftovers were reheated and passed around the large dining table. Morgan was eating with absolute, ravenous focus. Because her marathon color-correction appointment at the salon had taken five grueling hours, she had completely missed lunch, and she was making up for it now with a massive plate of baked ziti.

David sat between his mother and Meredith, a plate of warm food in front of him. The entire family—his parents, Kate's father, and the four cousins—were finally gathered together. It was time for the debrief.

Meredith set her fork down and looked across the table at the adults. With the same icy, clinical precision she used to dismantle threats in public, she laid out the exact sequence of events regarding Vesper Vance. She detailed the seemingly polite introduction in the student lounge, the walk to the mall, the deliberate isolation tactic in the glass elevator, and the sudden screaming over the lunch menu.

David's father stopped eating, his posture instantly rigid. Kate's father leaned forward, his eyes narrowing as he listened to the familiar, terrifying pattern of an outsider trying to corner a vulnerable member of their pack.

"The moment the elevator doors opened on the third floor, David threw himself at me," Meredith explained, her voice steady. "And the very first thing Vesper did wasn't to ask if he was okay. She stared directly at my chest, and then she glared at me like she didn't believe for a single second that we were actually cousins."

David let out a low, exasperated groan, tapping his hand against the table in annoyance. He knew exactly what Meredith meant. Meredith, Morgan, and Kate all possessed chests that were disproportionately large for their frames—a physical trait that made them constant targets for the neurotypical world's superficial, judgmental stares.

David couldn't possibly care less about any of that. To him, the women in his family were simply his safe harbor. Their frames meant that when the sensory overload of the world became too much, they gave the most amazing, secure, all-encompassing hugs that instantly grounded him. Society saw an aesthetic; David just saw the people who were always there to offer comfort.

The adults at the table exchanged a dark, knowing look. They didn't need to hear about the twins' secret plans for the Poop Button or the Pee Bag; the reality of the situation was serious enough.

David and Kate were eighteen years old, which meant they were officially and permanently under strict legal Guardianships and Conservatorships administered through the Circuit Court. Because of their lifelong mental incapacity, neither David nor Kate possessed the cognitive framework to ever legally consent to a sexual encounter. To the family, Vesper wasn't just an annoying college girl; if she was actively trying to isolate David for her own desires, she was a predator walking blindly toward a felony boundary violation.

"You handled it perfectly, Mer," David's father said, his voice thick with protective authority. He looked at both twins, silently validating the proxy guardianship powers he and his brother had officially delegated to them. "If she approaches him again on Wednesday, you shut it down immediately. You have full clearance."

Morgan swallowed a massive bite of ziti and pointed her fork across the table. "Don't worry, Uncle Leo. We've got it covered. She won't get within ten feet of him."

Kate, sitting across from David, offered a sharp, breathy giggle, fully aware of exactly *how* Morgan planned to keep Vesper away.

With the perimeter officially secured and the adults briefed, the tension at the table finally dissipated. David finished his leftovers, his eyes constantly darting toward the digital clock on the microwave.

It was 6:45 PM. He felt a nervous, excited flutter in his stomach. He just had to wait a little over two hours. At 9:00 PM, the exorbitant long-distance phone rates would finally drop. He could retreat to the safety of the converted garage, pick up the landline, and finally place the call across the Pacific Ocean to hear Hannah's voice in Honolulu.

Scene 13: The Evening Routine

Morgan stood in the center of the expansive, accessible bathroom, wrestling her waist-length, honey-caramel hair into a massive plastic claw clip. With a dramatic sigh, she stretched a crinkly, oversized plastic shower cap over her head, snapping the elastic band securely against her forehead.

"Tracy was very clear," Morgan announced, pointing a stern finger at Meredith as the twins wheeled David and Kate into the tiled room. "Seventy-two hours. The bleach blew my hair cuticles wide open. If I get this wet, or if I even stand in too much steam, this expensive toner washes right down the drain and I go back to looking like a rusty penny."

“Understood,” Meredith said, rolling up her sleeves. “You are officially banished from the splash zone.”

Within the walls of the converted garage, privacy and shyness simply did not exist. The evening caregiving routine was handled with the same casual, deeply practical love as making dinner. Modesty had long ago been replaced by absolute trust and clinical efficiency.

Morgan and Meredith seamlessly coordinated to assist David with his toileting routine, moving with practiced, gentle mechanics that preserved his dignity while handling his physical needs. Once David was settled, the twins turned their attention to Kate.

Meredith executed a flawless pivot-transfer, moving Kate from her manual wheelchair to the toilet. Morgan knelt beside her, retrieving the specialized fluid bags to connect to Kate’s MACE.

“Alright, initiate launch sequence,” Morgan deadpanned, prepping the hose to introduce the fluid into the surgical channel on Kate’s abdomen. “Preparing the Poop Chute for deployment. We need this hardware fully calibrated if we’re going to threaten Vesper with it on Wednesday.”

Kate’s shoulders began to shake immediately. She stared at the bathroom wall, trying her hardest to maintain a serious expression, but the sheer absurdity of the twins’ toilet humor broke her down into a series of silent, breathy giggles. David watched from his chair, double-blinking in warm amusement as Morgan efficiently unhooked Kate’s used urinary collection bag, properly disposing of it and swapping it out for a fresh, sterile plastic pouch.

When the medical maintenance was complete, it was time for the showers. Morgan stepped in to help Meredith carefully undress David and Kate, managing the heavy lifting and untangling of clothes. As soon as her cousins were ready for the water, Morgan backed toward the door, shielding her plastic-wrapped head.

“I’m out,” Morgan declared, pulling the door open. “Good luck in the humidity.”

Meredith groaned playfully as the door clicked shut. Stripping down to join her cousins in the shower was a daily necessity; it was the only way to safely support their spastic muscles and thoroughly wash their hair without soaking her own clothes. Following the strict rules of their household caregiving, she focused entirely on the practical mechanics of the routine, ensuring the warm water eased the tension in David and Kate’s limbs while maintaining the utmost respect for their physical boundaries.

“I literally cannot wait for this seventy-two-hour rule to be over,” Meredith complained over the hiss of the showerhead, carefully lathering David’s hair. “Doing the heavy lifting in here by myself is exhausting.”

Out in the cool, dry air of the garage barracks, Morgan changed into her comfortable cotton pajamas. She moved around the room, pulling out clean sleepwear for Meredith, Kate, and David, laying them out in neat piles on the edge of the massive, shared mattress.

She stared at the empty space on the bed where Hannah used to sleep.

“Man,” Morgan muttered quietly to herself, smoothing out a wrinkle in David’s favorite tagless shirt. “I really wish Hannah was here. Four sets of hands made this so much easier.”

But as the digital clock on the bedside table glowed 8:30 PM, Morgan smiled. The physical heavy lifting for the day was almost over. In just thirty minutes, the long-distance rates would drop, and the missing piece of their Vanguard would finally be on the other end of the line.

Scene 14: The Summons

The bathroom door cracked open just an inch, releasing a thick, humid cloud of warm air. Morgan stood in the dry hallway, her plastic shower cap firmly in place, extending her arms blindly through the gap to hand off the neat stacks of cotton pajamas.

“I’m keeping my distance,” Morgan called out through the crack. “Hurry up and get dressed. It’s almost nine.”

Inside, the shower was off, and Meredith worked with her usual clinical efficiency. She quickly dried and dressed herself, then moved seamlessly to assist David and Kate. Once they were comfortably in their pajamas and Kate’s fresh urinary collection bag was securely tucked out of the way, Meredith opened the door and wheeled her cousins out into the hallway.

They bypassed the converted garage entirely and headed straight for the living room, where David’s parents and Kate’s father were already gathered around the couch.

David parked his manual chair near the coffee table, pulling his travel keyboard onto his lap and ensuring it was securely tethered to the OmniTalk 3000. He watched the digital clock on the cable box flip from 8:59 to 9:00 PM.

The exorbitant long-distance rates had officially dropped.

David didn’t hesitate. He picked up the cordless landline receiver from the end table, dialed the familiar 808 area code, and pressed the phone between his ear and shoulder.

It rang exactly once before the line clicked open.

“David!” Hannah’s voice burst through the receiver. She sounded breathless, practically vibrating with excitement. But there was a slight, tinny echo to her voice. She was on speakerphone. “Don’t type anything yet. Put me on speaker on your end. Are the twins and your parents there? I need everyone to hear this!”

David blinked, completely caught off guard. He had fully prepared his AAC device for a standard, quiet recap of their respective first days of school. He fumbled slightly, pressing the speaker button on the handset and setting the phone down on the coffee table.

Meredith, Morgan, and the adults immediately leaned in, the low murmur of the living room dropping to absolute silence.

“We’re here, Hannah,” David’s dad said. “You’re on speaker. What’s going on?”

The deep, commanding voice of Lieutenant Commander Thomas Everett came through the line next. “Good evening, everyone. I hope you’re all sitting down, because I have an official announcement.”

David gripped the armrests of his wheelchair, his heart hammering against his ribs.

“After twenty years of serving Uncle Sam,” Tom continued, the immense pride evident in his tone, “my retirement paperwork has officially cleared. The ceremony will be held this summer at Naval Station Pearl Harbor. The date is Friday, June 25th, 2004. And consider this a direct, non-negotiable summons. I want the entire Delaney family in the front row.”

David let out a loud, sustained hum of absolute joy, his spastic muscles tightening with excitement. He looked at Morgan and Meredith, whose jaws had dropped in shock.

“But that’s not all,” Hannah’s voice cut back in, cutting through the cheers erupting in the Virginia Beach living room. “Dad gets a Home of Selection move from the Navy. They’re paying to ship all our stuff wherever we want.” She paused, and David could practically hear the smile on her face. “We chose Virginia Beach. We’re coming back for good.”

David slapped his hands onto his lap, overwhelmed by a rush of pure adrenaline. The two-year countdown was almost over.

“David,” Hannah said, her tone softening, speaking directly to him through the speakerphone. “I don’t care about the legal paperwork, or the guardianship, or any of that. None of it matters to me. I just want to be with you. We’re coming home.”

The sheer magnitude of the words hit David’s neurological system like a freight train. His autistic brain, which relied so heavily on routine and predictable data, simply could not process the overwhelming, infinite tidal wave of pure joy. It short-circuited entirely.

A severe, involuntary meltdown overtook him in an instant. A ragged, unshielded sob tore out of his throat, and tears began streaming down his face in hot, heavy tracks. The emotional overload immediately triggered the spasticity in his cerebral palsy; his limbs went rigid, his hands pulling awkwardly toward his chest as he gasped for air, crying his eyes out in the middle of the living room.

Meredith and Morgan did not hesitate for a single microsecond. The “Ice” and “Fire” protocols were abandoned completely. They lunged forward, sandwiching him in the center of his wheelchair. Morgan wrapped her arms fiercely around his chest, and Meredith pressed heavily against his back and shoulders. It was a bone-crushing, desperate hug, delivering immediate and maximum Deep Pressure Therapy to manually override his sensory overload.

On the coffee table, the speakerphone remained entirely free of judgment. Hannah and Tom didn’t hang up, and they didn’t try to talk over his sobs. They stayed right there on the line in Oahu, projecting absolute, unwavering patience. They knew exactly how David’s autism worked, and they refused to abandon him in his moment of need.

Tears soaked into Meredith's pajama shirt as David desperately tried to reach for his travel keyboard. His fine motor control was completely shattered by the spasms and the crying. He jabbed blindly at the keys, his trembling fingers slipping off the board. He let out a frustrated, heartbroken keen.

"I've got you," Meredith whispered, reaching down. She didn't type it for him; she simply placed her steady hand over his shaking one, guiding his stiff fingers to the correct keys, one by one.

He slammed the trigger.

"I love you," the robotic voice echoed, entirely failing to capture the massive, overwhelming emotion behind the words, but Hannah understood perfectly.

"I love you too," she promised, her own voice thick with unshed tears. "And you don't even have to wait until June to see me. Dad can't get leave from the command to travel, but he bought me a ticket. I'm flying into ORF to spend Christmas with you guys this year."

The absolute certainty in her voice, combined with the crushing, continuous weight of his cousins' embrace, finally broke through the static in David's mind. His breathing hitched, then slowly began to steady. Meredith and Morgan maintained their fierce grip until the rigid spasticity finally left his muscles, successfully anchoring him and pulling him out of the meltdown.

The living room exploded into celebration. Kate clapped her hands together, letting out a series of breathy giggles, while Morgan yanked her plastic shower cap off and threw it across the room in triumph.

For the next half hour, the phone call transitioned into a chaotic, joyous logistical planning session. They had ten months to prepare for the massive deployment across the Pacific Ocean. Meredith immediately grabbed a legal pad, taking notes on flight routes through Atlanta and gate-checking protocols for the manual wheelchairs. David's parents began calculating the time-off requests they would need to submit.

David just sat back in his chair, listening to the cross-talk between the people he loved most in the world. He didn't need to type anything else. Between Hannah coming for Christmas and the entire Vanguard flying to Oahu next summer, the agonizing era of long-distance survival was effectively dead.

He looked over at Meredith and Morgan, who were already enthusiastically debating the best way to pack Kate's medical supplies for a ten-hour flight. Vesper Vance and her petty, manipulative elevator traps felt a million miles away.

The perimeter was secure, and the anomaly was finally coming home.

Scene 15: The Vanguard Rests

The adrenaline of the phone call slowly gave way to the deep, heavy exhaustion of a long, emotionally massive day. As the adults dispersed to their own rooms and the house began to quiet down, Meredith and Morgan took the push handles of the manual wheelchairs and guided David and Kate back into the cool, familiar safety of the converted garage barracks.

With the evening caregiving routine already completed, all that was left was the final transition. Working in perfect, unspoken tandem, the twins assisted their cousins with the transfers. They moved Kate first, settling her comfortably into the center of the massive shared mattress and ensuring the tubing for her urinary collection bag was completely secure and unkinked for the night. Next, they helped David out of his chair, supporting his weight and gently easing him down onto the soft blankets right beside her.

As soon as his body hit the mattress, David reached out, his muscles loose and thoroughly relaxed after the earlier meltdown. He pulled Kate into a warm, secure cuddle. She nestled happily against his chest, letting out a soft, contented hum as she accepted the grounding weight of his embrace.

Meredith climbed onto the far left edge of the bed, pulling the thick comforter up over her shoulders. Morgan navigated around the manual wheelchairs parked at the foot of the bed and climbed onto the far right edge. By taking the outermost flanks, the identical twins effectively formed a physical, impenetrable perimeter. They acted as living, breathing bed rails, ensuring that if David or Kate's spastic muscles twitched or rolled during the night, they would be met with the safe, immovable presence of their fiercely protective cousins.

"Alright," Morgan said softly, reaching over to click off the bedside lamp. The garage plunged into a comfortable, quiet darkness, illuminated only by the faint amber glow of the digital clock. "Lights out, Vanguard. We have a war to plan for Wednesday."

Meredith let out a quiet, tired laugh from the other side of the bed. "Vesper doesn't stand a chance. Go to sleep."

Kate's breathing had already begun to slow and deepen, lulled by the safety of the sleep pile. But David lay perfectly awake in the dark, his arm draped protectively over Kate.

His body was exhausted, completely drained by the sensory input of the college campus, the mall, the hair salon, and the overwhelming emotional overload of the evening. Yet, his mind was absolutely racing. He stared up at the dark ceiling of the garage, a massive, unshielded smile spreading across his face.

The agonizing wait was finally breaking. The long-distance phone calls, the painful time zones, and the empty space in the bed were coming to an end. He didn't just have a plan to deal with his college class, and he didn't just have the absolute security of his family.

He had Christmas. He had June.

Hannah was coming home.

Chapter 2: The Virginia Beach Perimeter

Scene 1: Morning in the Barracks

The Tuesday morning sun filtered through the high, frosted windows of the converted garage, casting a soft, warm glow across the massive shared mattress.

There were no blaring alarms today. With Kate's Student Development class not scheduled until 1:00 PM at the CCHR Virginia Beach campus, the Vanguard was allowed the rare luxury of a slow, deeply peaceful morning.

In the center of the bed, David and Kate were still perfectly secure in their sleep pile. David's arm was draped loosely over Kate's waist, his breathing slow and even. On the outermost edges of the mattress, Meredith and Morgan remained firmly stationed as the living bed rails, their bodies creating an impenetrable physical perimeter.

Kate was the first to wake. She blinked her eyes open, feeling the comforting, heavy weight of David's arm anchoring her. She let out a quiet, contented hum, staring up at the familiar ceiling of the garage. But as the reality of the day began to boot up in her mind, a small knot of anxiety tightened in her chest.

Today was her turn.

She turned her head slightly, looking over at Morgan. Morgan was already awake, silently staring at the ceiling while wearing a massive, ridiculous silk sleep bonnet to protect her highly vulnerable, honey-caramel hair from the friction of the pillows.

Kate reached out, tapping a specific, rapid rhythm on the mattress near Morgan's elbow. *Are you all coming?*

Morgan turned her head, the silk bonnet shifting slightly. She offered Kate a soft, reassuring smile, immediately reading the anxiety behind the literal processing. Kate had listened to the entire debrief about Vesper Vance last night. After the trauma of Connor—who had used the guise of a polite, helpful student to isolate her—the thought of navigating a college campus alone, or even with just one cousin, was terrifying. She didn't want to risk running into a male version of Vesper. She wanted maximum security.

"Every single one of us is coming," Morgan whispered fiercely, reaching across the blankets to squeeze Kate's hand. "Meredith is driving, I'm riding shotgun, and David is rolling right next to you. It's a full Vanguard deployment."

On the other side of the bed, Meredith shifted, her pragmatic internal clock finally waking her up. She stretched her arms over her head and sat up, looking down at her cousins.

"Good morning," Meredith said, her voice rough with sleep. She looked at the digital clock on the nightstand, which read 8:45 AM. "We have hours before we need to leave for the Virginia Beach campus. We can take our time today."

David stirred at the sound of Meredith's voice, his muscles tightening slightly before relaxing as he realized where he was. He offered a sharp, happy grunt, pulling Kate into a brief, tight morning cuddle before letting go so they could start the day.

The morning routine was a masterclass in relaxed, coordinated efficiency. Meredith and Morgan climbed out of bed, pulling the manual wheelchairs over to the edge of the mattress. They assisted David and Kate with their morning transfers, moving them safely from the bed to their chairs.

Once they wheeled into the bathroom, the dynamic shifted back to the strict rules established by Tracy the cosmetologist.

"I'm on dry duty again," Morgan announced, adjusting her silk bonnet and keeping a safe distance from the sinks. "Meredith, you're handling the splash zone."

Meredith rolled her eyes playfully but immediately took point. She assisted Kate with her morning hygiene and efficiently checked her MACE site, ensuring the area was clean and secure. Then, she unhooked Kate's overnight urinary collection bag, properly disposing of the fluid and swapping it for a fresh, low-profile day bag that could be discreetly strapped to Kate's calf under her jeans.

By 9:30 AM, the entire Vanguard was dressed, transferred back to their chairs, and rolling into the Delaney Street kitchen for breakfast.

David parked his manual chair at the table and flipped open his laptop, tethering his travel keyboard to the OmniTalk 3000. He was still riding the incredible emotional high of last night's phone call with Hannah.

"Are you ready for your class?" the robotic voice asked, directed at Kate as she sat across from him.

Kate looked down at her own AAC device mounted to her wheelchair. She typed slowly, her expression serious.

"Yes," her device spoke, its tone perfectly flat. "As long as you are all there to stare menacingly at anyone who approaches me."

Morgan laughed, sliding a plate of toaster waffles onto the table in front of her. "Oh, we're going to do way more than stare, Kate. If any guy even thinks about pulling a Connor or a Vesper today, we're skipping Stage One entirely and going straight to threatening them with Acoustic Bathroom Warfare."

Kate buried her face in her hands, her shoulders shaking with silent, breathy giggles. It was absurd, but it worked. With the Vanguard surrounding her, the Virginia Beach campus didn't seem so scary after all.

Scene 2: The Acoustic Clarification

By noon, the slow, peaceful morning had transitioned into a highly coordinated military operation. The Vanguard assembled in the driveway around Meredith's practical sedan.

Meredith and Morgan operated like a well-oiled pit crew. Meredith took the driver's side, expertly transferring Kate into the backseat while managing the tubing of her day bag. Morgan handled the passenger side, assisting David into the seat right next to his cousin. In a matter of seconds, both manual wheelchairs were collapsed, stacked, and secured in the spacious trunk.

Meredith climbed behind the wheel, engaged the clutch, and shifted into first gear. As they pulled out of the Delaney Street driveway and headed toward the CCHR Virginia Beach campus, Kate tapped a specific, questioning rhythm against the back of Meredith's seat.

"Don't worry," Meredith said, glancing at Kate in the rearview mirror. "I know what you're asking. We've refined the protocol."

Morgan turned around in the passenger seat, carefully keeping her silk bonnet from snagging on the headrest. "Just to be absolutely clear on the rules of engagement today, Kate: we are not dragging anyone into a bathroom. That's kidnapping."

Kate nodded slowly, offering a deadpan blink. *Glad we established that.*

"Exactly," Morgan continued, a wicked grin spreading across her face. "Acoustic Warfare is a strictly mobile operation. If some guy tries to isolate you in the hallway or the student lounge, Meredith and I will simply execute a flanking maneuver. We will stand on either side of him and deploy maximum-volume, wet fog-horn noises in stereo."

David slapped his knee in the back seat, letting out a sharp, breathy giggle.

"We bring the Battle Shits directly to the customer," Meredith agreed, downshifting as they approached a red light. "Right out in the open. By the time we hit the second volley, he'll be questioning reality and running for the exits."

Kate buried her face in her hands, shaking her head. Through the gaps in her fingers, she was smiling. The sheer absurdity of her cousins threatening to publicly fart on an unsuspecting college student was ridiculous, but it completely eradicated her anxiety. A predator looking for a quiet, vulnerable target would never survive an encounter with the twins' chaotic energy.

Ten minutes later, Meredith pulled into the sprawling, suburban CCHR Virginia Beach campus. Unlike the vertical concrete towers of downtown Norfolk, the VB campus was a wide collection of brick buildings connected by open courtyards and massive parking lots.

Meredith parked in an accessible space near the main academic building. The twins jumped out, quickly retrieving the manual wheelchairs from the trunk. They transferred David and Kate with their usual clinical efficiency, ensuring Kate's leg bag was completely hidden beneath the hem of her jeans.

"Alright, Vanguard," Meredith said, slamming the trunk shut. "Formation."

They moved toward the glass entrance doors as a unified front. Kate rolled in the center, her hands gripping her push rims. David wheeled himself right beside her, his travel keyboard resting securely on his lap. Meredith and Morgan took the outer flanks, walking with their shoulders squared and their eyes scanning the crowds of college freshmen.

As they entered the air-conditioned hallway, Kate felt a profound wave of security wash over her. Students automatically stepped aside, giving the four of them a wide berth. No one was going to try and catch her alone today.

They navigated to the B-Wing, finding Kate's Student Development classroom with twenty minutes to spare. Unlike David's room with its tiny, restrictive bolted desks, this room had been recently updated with wide, modular tables.

Kate wheeled into a spot near the front, and David parked right next to her. Meredith and Morgan immediately claimed the two chairs directly behind them, establishing a physical barrier between their cousins and the rest of the room.

David typed quickly on his keyboard, hitting the trigger to send the text through his OmniTalk 3000.

"Perimeter secured," the robotic voice announced quietly to the group.

Morgan leaned forward, resting her elbows on the table behind Kate. "Let's see what the VB campus has to offer. My vocal cords are warmed up and ready for stereo."

Scene 3: The Princess Anne Perimeter

The Vanguard navigated the wide, sunny corridors of the Princess Anne Building, a sprawling brick complex at the heart of the Virginia Beach campus. Unlike David's experience in the cramped Martin Building, the hallways here were wide enough that they could easily roll two abreast.

As they approached the correct classroom, Morgan stopped the group in a quiet alcove just outside the door. She unzipped her backpack and pulled out a massive, gallon-sized zip-top plastic bag filled with a strange, brown-and-orange mixture.

"Behold," Morgan whispered, holding the bag up like a trophy. "Acoustic ammunition."

Kate stared at the bag. She tapped her wheelchair armrest, giving Morgan a highly skeptical look.

"It's a proprietary blend of dried apricots, roasted soy nuts, and sugar-free chocolate chips," Meredith explained, her clinical "Ice" protocol fully analyzing the nutritional data. "The apricots provide a massive hit of soluble fiber. The soy nuts offer heavy complex carbohydrates. And the sugar-free chocolate is loaded with maltitol. If consumed rapidly, the human digestive tract simply cannot process it."

"It creates rapid, highly pressurized gastrointestinal distress within thirty minutes," Morgan added, shaking the bag so the soy nuts rattled. "If some guy tries to corner you, Meredith and I will down two handfuls of this each. We will become weapons of mass flatulence."

David slapped his hands over his mouth, his shoulders shaking violently as he tried to contain a burst of laughter. Kate closed her eyes and let her head fall back against her headrest, letting out a series of breathy, silent giggles. The sheer, calculated insanity of her cousins' biological warfare planning was the perfect antidote to her first-day jitters.

“Keep it in the bag,” Kate’s AAC device stated flatly. “I am going in alone.”

Just like David had done on Monday, Kate was determined to tackle the actual classroom environment by herself. The Vanguard was her shield against the unpredictable hallways and the threat of isolation, but in the structured, heavily supervised environment of the classroom, she wanted to prove her independence.

“You’ve got this,” Meredith said, stepping back to clear the path.

“We’ll be right here,” Morgan promised, zipping the biological hazard mix safely back into her bag. “If you need us, just tap the SOS rhythm on your desk. We’ll hear it.”

Kate gave them a firm nod, gripped her push rims, and wheeled herself through the heavy wooden door.

The classroom was modern and spacious. She easily maneuvered her manual chair into a spot at an accessible table near the front. The professor, an older man with a kind smile, was busy writing the syllabus outline on the whiteboard. As the room slowly filled with other freshmen, Kate kept a watchful eye, but no one approached her with any undue interest. A few students offered polite smiles, which she returned, but the terrifying specter of another Connor never materialized.

Out in the hallway, the Vanguard held the perimeter. David backed his wheelchair against the wall, flipped open his laptop, and happily spent the next fifty minutes typing up a history essay draft while Meredith and Morgan stood guard, casually leaning against the brickwork and watching the flow of student traffic.

At exactly 1:50 PM, the classroom door swung open, and the students began to pour out.

Kate wheeled herself into the hallway, a look of profound relief on her face.

David immediately looked up from his laptop. He typed quickly, sending the text through the OmniTalk 3000. “Status report?”

Kate’s fingers moved across her own device. “The class was easy. We just went over the syllabus. And no one bothered me.”

Meredith let out a long breath, her posture relaxing completely. “Good. The perimeter holds.”

Morgan let out a dramatic sigh, patting the front pocket of her backpack. “Well, I’m glad you’re safe, Kate. But I’m not going to lie… part of me is a little disappointed I didn’t get to deploy the apricots.”

Kate rolled her eyes, but she reached out and grabbed Morgan’s hand, giving it a grateful squeeze. The first day of college was officially in the books for both of them, and against all odds, it had been a complete success.